

HERO'S JOURNEY NARRATIVE

From Humanitarian Leader to Aligned Business Coach

1. The Setup

For ten years, I stood in places most people only see on the news. I was head of Save the Children's rehousing program in Banda Aceh after the 2004 tsunami killed over 200,000 people. I built culturally sensitive homes for displaced families under severe logistical and cultural constraints. Before that, Gaza. After that, southern Serbia on post-conflict reconstruction. I led teams. I delivered results when failure meant families sleeping in the rubble.

People told me I was doing important work. They were right. Every morning I woke up knowing exactly what mattered. Service with no caveats. Meeting people where they are, not where you want them to be. I watched communities rise from catastrophic destruction through sheer resilience. I also watched opportunists exploit tragedy for self-promotion and grand standing. The contrast taught me everything about authentic service versus performance.

But something was breaking underneath the purpose. My wife. Our relationship. The constant moving, the toll of bearing witness to humanity's darkest moments and brightest resilience—it was eroding the foundation of everything I claimed to value. Freedom. Family. Peace. I was building homes for strangers while mine was crumbling.

2. The Fall

I took a corporate job in Darwin, Australia. A place nobody else wanted because of the heat, the isolation, the distance from everything that mattered to career-minded professionals. Perfect for a man who needed to disappear from the weight of what he'd been carrying.

Here's what nobody tells you about leaving meaningful work: the identity crisis doesn't hit immediately. At first, I felt relief. My wife was happy. We had stability. Darwin's relaxed lifestyle suited me. I could breathe.

Then the questions started. Who was I without the mission? Without leading teams through impossible situations? Without the daily confirmation that my work mattered in life-or-death terms? I'd gone from building homes for tsunami survivors to... corporate infrastructure projects in a town most Australians couldn't find on a map.

The inner child wound I'd been medicating with achievement and service suddenly had nowhere to hide. My mother pushed me to be my best in all things. I'd spent forty-plus years proving I could become what she—and I—thought I should be. But corporate middle management in Darwin? That wasn't the story I'd imagined.

So I did what every ambitious person does when facing an identity crisis: I looked for the next mountain to climb. I'd build an online business. I'd achieve freedom and impact and financial success all at once. How hard could it be compared to building homes in a war zone?

3. The Struggle

Five years. Tens of thousands of dollars. Multiple business models that looked good on paper but felt wrong in execution.

First, affiliate marketing. Selling other people's products. Made perfect sense logically—no product creation, just traffic and conversion. But every day I showed up to promote someone else's work felt like putting on clothes that didn't fit. It was misaligned, though I couldn't articulate why at the time.

Then coaching. I loved the interaction with people. It felt closer to the service I'd known. But it was draining in a way humanitarian work never was. My clients didn't get results. Not because the strategy was wrong, but because they fundamentally underestimated what was required. They wanted transformation without the repeated failures, the setbacks, the grinding consistency that character-building demands. When they quit at the first real obstacle, I felt like I was failing them. Maybe I was.

I tried quitting corporate once. Thought maybe the problem was that I wasn't fully committed. That experiment lasted long enough to teach me an expensive lesson: when survival depends on making sales, your energy shifts. Desperation seeps into every interaction. I became the thing I despised—someone more focused on getting paid than genuinely serving. I went back to corporate with my tail between my legs.

The real struggle wasn't external. It was the voice asking if I was cut out for this. Five years is a long time to fail. My engineering brain kept seeking the clear blueprint, the proven system, the path of least resistance. But entrepreneurship doesn't work like project management. There's no approved plan you execute. You build the bridge while walking on it.

4. The Discovery

The breakthrough wasn't a strategy. It was a mirror.

I was doing inner child work—the kind that makes engineers uncomfortable—when I saw it clearly for the first time: I'd been building businesses to prove I was enough. To show my mother, my peers, myself that I could succeed at this too. Every failure reinforced the wound rather than healing it. And every business model I chose was someone else's definition of success, not mine.

Affiliate marketing failed because selling other people's products didn't align with my value of authentic service. Coaching failed because I was trying to take people on a transformation journey I hadn't completed myself. I was the humanitarian worker turned corporate employee telling people how to build freedom-based businesses. The cognitive dissonance was crushing me.

Then the simple truth: You can't grow into pain.

If showing up in your business feels like forcing yourself into clothes that don't fit, you will eventually quit. Not because you're weak or uncommitted, but because human beings can't sustain misalignment. The coaches I'd watched fail? They weren't flawed. They were building businesses they fundamentally couldn't grow into because those businesses weren't true to who they actually were.

I needed to build something different. Not another guru's blueprint. Something that aligned with my engineering mindset, my need for measurable outcomes, my understanding that real transformation takes time, and my refusal to exploit people's desperation. Something I could actually sustain.

5. The Test

I applied project management thinking to business building: test before you build infrastructure.

Instead of creating another massive coaching program nobody would buy, I created a \$7 offer. A simple pain killer. Something that solved one burning problem for coaches struggling to get clients. If nobody would pay \$7, they definitely wouldn't pay \$2,000. But if they did pay \$7, I'd know they had skin in the game—they'd raised their hand that they actually wanted to solve this problem, not just collect more free content.

I put it out there. Within days, seven people bought it. A couple added the order bump. It wasn't life-changing money. But it was something far more valuable: validation. Real people, spending real money, because what I created actually helped them move forward.

For five years, I'd been chasing big launches and high-ticket clients and overnight success. Seven \$7 sales taught me more than any of that. They taught me that starting small, testing fast, and building from proven ground works. They taught me that my engineering approach—test, validate, scale—could actually work in business if I stopped trying to skip straight to the scale part.

More importantly, creating that offer felt like flow, not force. I wasn't dreading showing up. I wasn't performing or pretending. I was just... helping people with something I actually understood.

6. The Breakthrough

Here's where I'm supposed to tell you about the six-figure launch, the corporate job I quit, the laptop lifestyle in Bali.

That's not this story.

My breakthrough was realizing I don't need that story. The real breakthrough was understanding that keeping my corporate job isn't a failure—it's strategic wisdom. It means I can build with integrity. I'm not desperate for every sale. I'm not corrupted by the pressure to promise what I can't deliver. I can tell coaches the truth: don't quit your job until you have something tested and viable, because desperate energy destroys everything it touches.

The breakthrough was accepting that five years of 'failure' gave me something no quick success ever could: I understand exactly what coaches go through when they're three years in, investment deep, wondering if they should quit. I can meet them where they are because I'm standing right there with them.

The breakthrough was realizing that 'enough' doesn't mean 10x my corporate salary in passive income (though that's still the goal). Enough means peace. It means waking up without dreading the day ahead. It means building something true to who I actually am, not who I think I should be.

Seven sales proved the model works. But the real victory was the shift from seeking external validation to trusting internal alignment. That's the breakthrough that changes everything, even if the bank account hasn't caught up yet.

7. The Transformation

Before: I was a humanitarian leader turned corporate employee, trying to build an online business by following other people's blueprints, seeking external validation through achievement, measuring worth by financial metrics I hadn't hit yet.

After: I'm a business coach who's built credibility through struggle, not just success. I understand that alignment matters more than tactics. I know that resilience over five years beats overnight wins. I've learned that the inner work and the outer work can't be separated—your business will only grow as much as you've grown.

The wisdom I've gained: Most entrepreneurs underestimate how long it takes to build something aligned. They jump from model to model, guru to guru, looking for the magic bullet outside themselves when the real work is internal. They're building businesses they'll eventually hate because they're following someone else's definition of success.

I've learned that flow and ease should be at the heart of any coaching business. If you dread showing up, you're in the wrong business—regardless of how much money it could make. You can't grow into pain. Period.

I've learned that people have fundamentally stopped thinking for themselves. They've delegated their thinking to gurus, hoping someone else has the answer. But true freedom comes from within—from reprogramming your subconscious toward abundance while building a business that actually fits who you are.

Most importantly: I've learned that nobody is coming to save you. Not a coach, not a course, not a strategy. You save yourself by building something sustainable, authentic, and true. And that takes longer than any guru wants to admit.

8. The Teaching Moment

If you're three years into building a coaching business and questioning everything, you're not behind. You're right on schedule. The coaches who quit after six months never learn what you're learning: that resilience matters more than strategy, that alignment beats tactics, that slow sustainable growth outlasts every overnight success story.

Here's what I wish someone had told me five years ago: Stop looking for the path of least resistance. There isn't one. But there is a path of true resistance—building something so aligned with who you are that showing up feels like flow, not force. That's the only path worth taking.

Test your offers fast. Don't build the entire infrastructure before you know if anyone will buy. A \$7 offer that gets seven sales tells you more than a \$2,000 program nobody purchases. Start small, validate quickly, build from proven ground.

Keep your job until you have something tested and viable. The gurus won't tell you this because it doesn't sound sexy. But building from abundance instead of desperation changes everything. Your energy. Your offers. Your integrity.

And do the inner work. Whatever you're running from—the need to prove you're enough, the fear of being seen, the wound driving your achievement—it will sabotage every business you build until you heal it. Personal development and business growth cannot be separated.

9. The Bridge

So what does this mean for you?

If you're a coach who's been posting content hoping clients will magically appear, trying to build what your last coach taught you even though it feels wrong, or wondering if you should quit because it's taking too long—I've built something specifically for you.

Not another promise of quick wins. Not another guru blueprint that worked for them but won't work for you. Something different: a system for extracting your unique zone of genius, validating it with a low-ticket offer that proves people will pay to solve their problem, then building a funnel that moves them naturally into your high-ticket programs.

The same system that got me those seven sales and order bumps—the validation that proved this model works. The system I'm using to build the business I can actually sustain because it's aligned with who I am, not who someone told me I should be.

But here's the thing: this only works if you're willing to think for yourself, do the inner work, and build sustainably instead of chasing overnight success. If you're looking for the magic bullet or the shortcut, I'm not your guy. But if you're ready to build something true...

10. Information Gaps & Notes

Potential areas for narrative enhancement:

1. Specific dollar amount of total investment over 5 years (currently 'tens of thousands')
2. More concrete details about what the \$7 offer specifically solved and why those 7 people bought

3. Specific pivotal moment or conversation that triggered the inner child work awareness
4. More detail about the corporate job quit attempt—how long did it last, what specifically went wrong
5. Any specific client success stories or testimonials from the 7 buyers (even informal feedback)
6. Timeline details—when each major pivot happened within the 5 years

Narrative Positioning Note:

This hero's journey is unique because Michael hasn't 'arrived' yet in the traditional sense—he's still building, still in corporate, still working toward the 10x income goal. However, this positioning is actually STRONGER for his ideal client (coaches 2-5 years in, still struggling) because:

- He's in the arena with them, not speaking from the other side
- His credibility comes from struggle and wisdom, not just results
- His counter-cultural positioning (keep your job, build sustainably) differentiates him completely
- His humanitarian background provides unassailable authority about what actually matters
- His 'transformation' is about mindset and alignment rather than just money, which resonates deeply with coaches burned by guru culture